

"It's good for you and the environment"

WHEN YOU READ THROUGH ALL THE STATEMENTS POSTED BY BOTH SIDES OF THE RIGHT TO REPAIR ARGUMENT, YOU MIGHT END UP A LITTLE CONFUSED. The subtle art of spin has had both sides twisting their own stances and portraying themselves as being the champions for the environment. Right to Repair advocates are of the stance that if the products can be repaired then fewer products need to be manufactured in the first place, and therefore, less precious resources will have to be expended over the life cycle of the product. On the other side of the argument, you have manufacturers claiming that they will take back the products and reuse the components from older products in newer products which means fewer products need to be manufactured in the first place, and therefore, less precious resources will have to be expended over the life cycle of the product. Which one of these is right?

Well, they both are, but the implication for the consumer is vastly different. In the first case, i.e. the side of the Right to Repair advocates, it costs the product manufacturers nothing to make the schematics of their products openly available. Spare parts can be manufactured by the product manufacturer or by third parties and the life-cycle of each product can be extended for much longer than what they are now. Money made off the repairs is divided between the product manufacturer, third party replacements manufacturers, repair shops, and by those making the tools that are used by said repair shops.

In the other case, where the manufacturer controls everything, there are additional logistics involved in collecting older phones, having them sent back to the factories, getting them removed to be tested for wear and tear before deciding to reuse the components in newer products. The manufacturer does not make the schematics openly accessible, and therefore, the money made off the repairs or recycled products is divided between no one and the product manufacturer keeps it all. VIVA CAPITALISM!

What about the environment? Ah! yes. The environment. "Reusing" is often touted as being great for the environment by folks

whose understanding of product life cycles is abysmal. Everything degrades over time. There is mechanical degradation of moving parts such as buttons and slide mechanisms. And there is electromechanical degradation of passive components such as transistors, capacitors, resistors, display screens and everything that you can think of. So when you decide to reuse something in a new product, it has to last you a certain amount of time for it to be a feasible replacement. After all, you wouldn't want to keep replacing products every couple of weeks, would you? So when product manufacturers have to take the call of reusing components, they have to consider a threshold in the life-cycle of a component. If the component is young, it can be reused, otherwise, it has to be smelt down and be remade into a new component. And just to make it clear, anyone can remake components, not just the manufacturer, so this aspect of reusing works in favour of both sides of the debate.

So wait, are both parties are in the green then? To an extent, yes. Both parties are indeed taking steps to show that their side of the argument is the right one. It's just that the logic that connects the "better for the environment" part doesn't easily connect to their individual stances. Moreover, the more obvious thing that emerges from all this is that the product manufacturers want to keep all the money to be made from repairs. The difference here is that a lot more mouths are fed when more stakeholders are involved and the actual cost for the end-consumer is vastly lower when dealing with local repair shops rather than going to the product manufacturer.

Let's not harp about quality here. I left that part out intentionally because we're dealing with product manufacturers who have been known to ship faulty components and remain tight-lipped about them for years. It would be extremely hypocritical of them to position themselves as the champions of quality.

If this simplistic take has you intrigued on the whole right to repair debate then our cover story this month should help you figure out where you stand. [d](#)



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